Story in Harlem Slang from Spunk

By Zora Neale Hurston

It is suggested that the rhythms of the dialect be played, instead of the dialect itself. A subtle but important distinction: The former will give you Zora. The latter, Amos and Andy.
The emotional states of the characters should not be sacrificed for "style." Nor should style be sacrificed because it gets in the way of the emotions. The preferred blend is one in which stylized gesture and speech are fueled by the emotional states.

*Lights reveal **SLANG TALK MAN:** his attire, very debonair; his manner of speaking, very smooth.*

SLANG TALK MAN: Wait till I light up my coal-pot and tell you about this Zigaboo called Jelly.

(On Slang Talk Man's signal, lights reveal Jelly, a hick trying to pass himself off as slick. He wears a stocking cap and underneath his "street" bravado is a boyish charm.)

JELLY: Well all right now!
SLANG TALK MAN: He was sealskin brown and papa-tree-top tall.
JELLY: Skinny in the hips and solid built for speed.
SLANG TALK MAN: He was born with this rough-dried hair, but when he laid on the grease and pressed it down overnight with his stocking cap. . .
JELLY: *(pulls off the cap to admire his "do":* It looked just like righ-teous moss.
SLANG TALK MAN: Had so many waves, you got seasick from lookin'.
JELLY: Solid man solid.
SLANG TALK MAN: His mama named him Marvel, but after a month on Lenox Avenue. . . *(On Slang Talk Man's signal, a zoot-suit jacket and hat magically appear.)*
SLANG TALK MAN: He changed all that to
JELLY: *(getting dressed)* Jelly.
SLANG TALK MAN: How come? Well he put it in the street that when it comes to filling that long-felt need. . .
JELLY: Sugar-curing the ladies' feelings. . .

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SLANG TALK MAN: He was in a class by himself. And nobody knew his name, so he had to tell 'em.

JELLY: It must be Jelly cause jam don't shake!

SLANG TALK MAN: That was what was on his sign. The stuff was there and it was mellow. N' whenever he was challenged by a hard-head or a frail eel on the right of his title, he would eyeball the idol-breaker with a slice of ice and say

JELLY: Youse just dumb. to the fact, baby. If you don't know what you talking 'bout, you better ask Granny Grunt. I wouldn't mislead you baby. I don't need to. Not with the help I got.

SLANG TALK MAN: Then he would give the pimp's sign. . . (*Jelly/Slang Talk Man adopt an exaggerated "street" pose;/or Slang Talk Man it's empty posturing; for Jelly it's the real deal.)*

SLANG TALK MAN: And percolate on down the Avenue.*(On Slang Talk Man's signal, the Footnote Voice is heard. As the Voice speaks Jelly practices a series of poses.)*

INTRODUCTION

FOOTNOTE VOICE: Please note. In Harlemese, pimp has a different meaning than its ordinary definition. The Harlem pimp is a man whose amatory talents are for sale to any woman who will support him, either with a free meal or on a common-law basis; in this sense, he is actually a male prostitute.

"Story in Harlem Slang," defines current Harlem slang by creating a conversation between three Harlem pimps representing various generations: Slang Talk Man, Sweet Back, a fur coat and platform shoe wearing dandy, and Jelly in a full-tilt zoot suit. They're trying to get women to notice them, and the piece plays for pure laughs. Story in Harlem Slang from Spuk by Zora Neale Hurston.

SLANG TALK MAN: So this day he was airing out on the Avenue. It had co be late afternoon, or he would not have been out of bed.

JELLY: Shoot, all you did by rolling out early was to stir your stom-ach up. *(Confidentially.)* That made you hunt for more dishes codirty. The longer you slept, the less you had to eat.

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SLANG TALK MAN: But you can't collar nods all day. So Jelly. . . *(Music underscore.)*

SLANG TALK MAN: Got into his zoot suit with the reet pleats and got out to skivver around and do himself some good.

(The transformation from "jelly the Hick" into "jelly the Slick" is now complete. He struts and poses like a tiger on the prowl; his moves suggestive, arrogant, mocking. Lights reveal Blues SPeak Woman and Guitar Man, sitting outside the playing arena, scatting vocalise which accents jelly's moves.)

JELLY: No matter how long you stay in bed, and how quiet you keep, sooner or later that big guts is going to reach over and grab that little one and start to gnaw. That's confidential from the Bible. You got to get out on the beat and collar yourself a hot!

SLANG TALK MAN: At 132nd Street, he spied one of his colleagues Sweet Back! Standing on the opposite sidewalk, in front of a café

(Lights reveal Sweet Back, older than jelly; the wear and tear of the street is starting to reveal itself in Sweet Back's face. Nonetheless, he moves with complete finesse as he and Jelly stalk each other, each trying to outdo the other as they strut, pose and lean.)

SLANG TALK MAN: jelly figured that if he bull-skated just right, he might confidence Sweet Back out of a thousand on a plate. Maybe a shot of scrap-iron or a reefer. Therefore, they both cook a quick backward look at the soles of their shoes to see how their leather was holding out. They then stanched out inco the street and made the crossing. *(Music underscore ends.)*

JELLY: Hey there, Sweet Back. Gimme some skin!

SWEET BACK: Lay the skin on me pal. Ain't seen you since the last time, Jelly. What's cookin'?

JELLY: Oh, just like the bear, I ain't no where. Like the bear's brother, I ain't no further. Like the bear's daughter, ain't got a quarter.

SLANG TALK MAN: Right away he wished he had not been so honest. Sweet Back gave him a

SWEET BACK: Top-superior, cut-eye look.

SLANG TALK MAN: Looked at Jelly just like

SWEET BACK: A showman looks at an ape.

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SLANG TALK MAN: Just as far above Jelly as fried chicken is over branch water.

SWEET BACK: Cold in the hand huh? A red hoc pimp like you say you is ain't got no business in the barrel. Last night when I left you, you was beating up your gums and broadcasting about how hot you was. Just as hot as July jam, you told me. What you doin' cold in hand?

JELLY: Aw man, can't you take a joke? I was just beating up my gums when I said I was broke. How can I be broke when I got the best woman in Harlem? If I ask her for a dime, she'll give me a ten-dollar bill. Ask her for a drink of likker, and she'll buy me a whiskey still. If I'm lyin' I'm flyin'!

SWEET BACK: Man, don't hang out that dirty washing in my back yard. Didn't I see you last night with that beat chick, scoffing a hot dog? That chick you had was beat to the heels. Boy, you ain't no good for what you live. And you ain't got nickel one. *(As if to a passing woman.)* Hey baby!

SLANG TALK MAN: Jelly

JELLY: Threw back the long skirt of his coat.

SLANG TALK MAN: And rammed his hand into his pants pocket. Sweet Back

SWEET BACK: Made the same gesture. . .

SLANG TALK MAN: Of hauling out nonexistent money.

JELLY: Put your money where your mouth is. Back yo' crap with your money. I bet you five dollars.

SWEET BACK: Oh yeah!

JELLY: Yeah. *(jelly/Sweet Back move toward each other, wagging their pants pockets at each other.)*

SWEET BACK: *(Playfully)* Jelly-Jelly-Jelly. I been raised in the church. I don't bet. But I'll doubt you. Five rocks!

JELLY: I thought so. (Loud talking.) I knowed he'd back up when I drawed my roll on him.

SWEET BACK: You ain't drawed no roll on me, Jelly. You ain't drawed nothing bUt your pocket. *(With an edge.)* You better stop that boogerbooing. Next time I'm liable to make you do it.

SLANG TALK MAN: There was a splinter of regret in Sweet Back's voice. If Jelly really had had some money, he might have staked him to a hot. .

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SWEET BACK: Good Southern cornbread with a piano on a platter.

SLANG TALK MAN: Oh well! The right broad would. . . might come.

JELLY: Who boogerbooing? Jig, I don't have to. Talkin' about me with a beat chick scoffing a hot dog? Man you musta not seen me, 'cause last night I was riding 'round in a Yellow Cab, with a yellow gal, drinking yellow likker, and spending yellow money. *(To the audience.)* Tell 'em 'bout me. You was there. Tell 'em!

SWEET BACK: Git out of my face Jelly! That broad I seen you with wasn't no pe-ola. She was one of them coal-scuttle blondes with hair just as close to her head as ninety-nine to hundred. She looked like she had seventy-five pounds of clear bosom, and she lookted like six months in front and nine months behind. Buy you a whiskey still! That broad couldn't make the down payment on a pair of sox.

JELLY: Naw-naw-naw-now Sweet Back, long as you been knowing me, you ain't never seen me with nothing but pe-olas. I can get any frail eel I wants to. How come I'm up here in New York? Huh-huh-huh? You don't know, do you? Since youse dumb to the fact, I reckon I'll have to make you hep. I had to leave from down south cause Miss Anne used to worry me so bad to go with her. Who me? Man, I don't deal in no coal.

SWEET BACK: Aww man, you trying to show your grandma how to milk ducks. Best you can do is confidence some kitchen-mechanic out of a dime or two. Me, I knocks the pad with them cackbroads up on Sugar Hill and fills 'em full of melody. Man, I'm quick death 'n' easy judgment. You just a home-boy, Jelly. Don't try to follow me.

JELLY: Me follow you! Man, I come on like the Gang Busters and go off like The March of Time. If that ain't so, God is gone co Jersey City and you know He wouldn't be messing 'round a place like that.

SLANG TALK MAN: Looka there! *(Sweet Back/jelly scurry and look.)*

SLANG TALK MAN: Oh well, the right broad might come along.

JELLY: Know what my woman done? We hauled off and went to church last Sunday. And when they passed 'round the plate for the penny collection, I throwed in a dollar. The man

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looked at me real hard for that. That made my woman mad, so she called him back and throwed in a tWenty-dollar bill. Told him to take that and go! That's what he got for looking at me 'cause I throwed in a dollar.

SWEET BACK: Jelly. . .

The wind may blow
And the door may slam.
That what you shooting
Ain't worth a damn!

JELLY: Sweet Back you fixing co talk out of place.

SWEET BACK: If you tryin' to jump salty Jelly, that's yo' mammy.

JELLY: Don't play in the family Sweet Back. I don't play the dozens. I done told you.

SLANG TALK MAN: Jelly

JELLY: Slammed his hand in his bosom as if to draw a gun.

SLANG TALK MAN: Sweet Back

SWEET BACK: Did the same. .

JELLY: If you wants to fight, Sweet Back, the favor is in me. *(jelly/Sweet Back begin to circle one another, each waiting on the other to "strike" first.)*

SWEET BACK: I was deep-thinking then, Jelly. It's a good thing I ain't shore-tempered. Tain't nothing to you nohow.

JELLY: Oh yeah. Well, come on.

SWEET BACK: No you come on.

SWEET BACK/JELLY: (overlapping): Come on! Come on! Come on! Come on! *(They are now in each other's lace, grimacing, snarling, ready to fight, when Sweet Back throws Jelly a look.)*

SWEET BACK: You ain't hit me yet. *(They both begin to laugh, which grows, until they are falling all over each other: the best of friends.)*

SWEET BACK: Don't get too yaller on me Jelly. You liable to get hurt some day.

JELLY: You over-sports your hand yo' ownself. Too blamed astor perious. I just don't pay 'you no mind. Lay the skin on me man.

SLANG TALK MAN: They broke their handshake hurriedly, because both of them looked up the A venue and saw the same thing.

SWEET BACK/JELLY: It was a girl. *(Music underscore as lights reveal the girl, busily posing and preening.)*

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SLANG TALK MAN: And they both remembered that it was Wednesday afternoon. All the domestics off for the afternoon with their pay in their pockets.

SWEET BACK/JELLY: Some of them bound to be hungry for love.

SLANG TALK MAN: That meant. . .

SWEET BACK: Dinner!

JELLY: A shot of scrap-iron!

SWEET BACK: Maybe room rent!

JELLY: A reefer or two!

SLANG TALK MAN: They both. . .

SWEET BACK: Went into the pose.

JELLY: And put on the look. (Loud talking.) Big stars falling.

SLANG TALK MAN: Jelly said out loud when the girl was in hearing distance.

JELLY: It must be just before day!

SWEET BACK: Yeah man. Must be recess in Heaven, pretty angel like that out on the ground.

SLANG TALK MAN: The girl drew abreast of them, reeling and rocking her hips. (*Blues Speak Woman scats as the girl struts, her hips working to the beat of the music. Jelly and Sweet Back swoop in and begin their moves.)*

JELLY: I'd walk clear to Diddy-Wah-Diddy to get a chance to speak to a pretty Ii'l ground-angel like that.

SWEET BACK: Aw, man you ain't willing to go very far. Me, I'd go slap to Ginny-Gall, where they eat cow-rump, skin and all.

SLANG TALK MAN: The girl smiled, so Jelly set his hat and took the plunge..

JELLY: Ba-by, what's on de rail for de lizard?

SLANG TALK MAN: The girl halted and braced her hips with her hands. *(Music underscore stops.)*

GIRL: A Zigaboo down in Georgy, where I come from, asked a woman that one time and the judge told him ninety days. *(Music underscore continues.)*

SWEET BACK: Georgy! Where 'bouts in Georgy you from? Delaware?

JELLY: Delaware? My people! My people! Man, how you going to put Delaware in Georgy. You ought to know that's in Maryland. *(Music underscore stops.)*

GIRL: Oh, don't try to make out youse no northerner, you! Youse from right down in 'Barn your ownself.

JELLY: Yeah, I'm from there and I aims to stay from there.

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GIRL: One of them Russians, eh? Rushed up here to get away from a job of work. *(Music underscore continues.)*

SLANG TALK MAN: That kind of talk was not leading towards the dinner table.

JELLY: But baby! That shape you got on you! I bet the Coca-Cola company is paying you good money for the patent!

SLANG TALK MAN: The girl smiled with pleasure at this, so Sweet Back jumped in.

SWEET BACK: I know youse somebody swell to know. Youse real people. There's dickty jigs 'round here tdes to smile. You grins like a regular fellow.

SLANG TALK MAN: He gave her his most killing look and let it simmer.

SWEET BACK: S'pose you and me go inside the cafe here and 'grab a hot. *(Music underscore ends.)*

GIRL: You got any money?

SLANG TALK MAN: The girl asked and stiffed like a ramrod.

GIRL: Nobody ain't pimping on me. You, dig me?

SWEET BACK/JELLY: Aww now baby!

GIRL: I seen you two mullet-heads before. I was uptown when Joe Brown had you all in the go-long last night. That cop sure hates a pimp. All he needs to see is the pimps' salute and he'll out with his night-stick and ship your head to the red. Beat your head just as flat as a dime. *(The girls sounds off like a siren. Sweet Back and Jelly rush to silence her.)*

SWEET BACK: Ah-ah-ah, let's us don't talk about the law. Let's talk about us. About you goin' inside with me to holler, "Let one come flopping! One come grunting! Snatch one from the rear!"

GIRL: Naw indeed. You skillets is trying to promote a meal on me. But it'll never happen, brother. You barking up the wrong tree. I wouldn't give you air if you was stopped up in a jug. I'm not putting out a thing. I'm just like the cemetery. I'm not putting out, I'm takin' in. Dig. I'll tell you like the farmer told the. potato-plant you now and dig you later. *(Music underscore.)*

SLANG TALK MAN: The girl made a movement to switch off. Sweet Back had not dirtied a plate since the day before. He made a weak but desperate gesture. *(just as Sweet Back places his hand on her purse, the girl turns to stare him down. Music underscore ends.)*

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GIRL: Trying to snatch my pocketbook, eh?

SLANG TALK MAN: Instead of running. . .

GIRL: *(grabs Sweet Back's zoot-suit jacket)* How much split you want back here? If your feets don't hurry up and take you 'way from here, you'll ride away. I'll spread my lungs all over New York and call the law. (*jelly moves in to try and calm her.)* Go ahead. Bedbug! Touch me! I'll holler like a pretty white woman! *(The girl lets out three "pretty white woman" screams and then struts off. Music underscores her exit.)*

SLANG TALK MAN: She turned suddenly and rocked on off, her earring snapping and her heels popping.

SWEET BACK: My people, my people.

SLANG TALK MAN: Jelly made an effort to appear that he had no part in the fiasco.

JELLY: I know you feel chewed.

SWEET BACK: Oh let her go. When I see people without the periodical principles they's supposed to have, I just don't fool with 'em. *(Calling out after her.)* What I want to steal her old pocketbook with all the money I got? I could buy a beat chick like you and give you away. I got money's mammy and Grandma's change. One of my women, and not the best one I got neither, is buying me ten shag suits at one time. He glanced sidewise at Jelly to see if he was convincing.

JELLY: But Jelly's thoughts were far away. *(Music underscore.)*

SLANG TALK MAN: He was remembering those full hot meals he had left back in Alabama to seek wealth and splendor in Harlem without working. He had even forgotten to look cocky and rich. *(The lights slowly fade)*

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Glossary for "Story in Harlem Slang"

AIR OUT: leave, flee, stroll
ASTORPERIOUS: haughty, biggity
'BAM, DOWN IN 'BAM: down South
BEATING UP YOUR GUMS: talking to no purpose
BULL-SKATING: bragging
COLLAR A NOD: sleep
COAL-SCUTTLE BLONDE: black woman
CUT: doing something well
DIDDY-WAH-DIDDY: (1) a far place, a measure of distance; (2) another suburb of Hell, built since way before Hell wasn't no bigger than Baltimore. The folks in Hell go there for a big time.
DUMB TO THE FACT: "You don't know what you're talking about."
FRAIL EEL: pretty girl
GINNY GALL: a suburb of Hell, a long way off
GRANNY GRUNT: a mythical character to whom most questions may be referred
I DON'T DEAL IN COAL: "I don't keep company with black women." JIG: Negro, a corrupted shortening of Zigaboo
JELLY: sex
JULY JAM: something very hot
JUMP SALTY: get angry
KITCHEN MECHANIC: a domestic
MANNY: a term of insult; never used in any other way by Negroes
MISS ANNE: a white woman
MY PEOPLE! MY PEOPLE!: sad and satiric expression in the Negro language; sad when a Negro comments on the backwardness of some members of his race; at other times, used for satiric or comic effect.
PE-OLA: a very white Negro girl
PIANO: spareribs (white rib bones suggest piano keys)
PLAYING THE DOZENS: low-rating the ancestors of your opponent
REEFER: a marijuana cigarette, also a drag
RIGHTEOUS MOSS OR GRASS: good hair
RUSSIAN: a southern Negro up North. "Rushed up here," hence a Russian
SCRAP-IRON: cheap liquor
SOLID: perfect
STANCH or STANCH OUT: to begin, commence, step out
SUGAR HILL: northwest sector of Harlem, near Washington Heights; site of the newest apartment houses, mostly occupied by professional people. (The expression has been distorted in the South to mean a Negro red-light district.)
THE BEAR: confession of poverty
THOUSAND ON A PLATE: beans
WHAT'S ON DE RAIL FOR THE LIZARD?: suggestion for moral turpitude
ZIGABOO: a Negro
ZOOT SUIT WITH THE REET PLEAT: Harlem-style suit with padded shoulders, 43-inch trousers at the knee with cuff so small it needs a zipper to get into, high waistline, fancy lapels, bushels of buttons, etc.

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